

CHAPTER 3

ELEVEN STRATEGIES TO OPTIMIZE REACHING YOUR GOALS

Although reaching your goals cannot be guaranteed, raise the probability of achieving them with the eleven strategies discussed in this chapter.

Before reading on, review the questions on the next page and mark your responses. Then score yourself using the information that follows the questions.

KNOW THE RESOURCES REQUIRED FOR REACHING A GOAL

Personal desire for reaching a goal is powerful, but often other resources are needed as well. What resources do you need to reach your goals—time, money, position? Additional education? The help of a particular person?

For example, consider the goal of purchasing a computer system for your home office. The resources you might need include: money to purchase the computer, the software, and the printer; additional knowledge for knowing how to use it; and the help of a computer consultant.

Now, consider one of your goals. What specific resources are needed for its achievement?

Goal:

Resources Required:

ELEVEN STRATEGIES FOR GOAL SETTING

	Often	Sometimes	Rarely/ Never
1. I know what resources I need to reach my goals.	_____	_____	_____
2. I work toward goals that are compatible with one another.	_____	_____	_____
3. I am comfortable asking for help to reach my goals.	_____	_____	_____

4. I accept the responsibility for working toward my goals.	_____	_____	_____
5. I minimize interruptions that get in the way of reaching my goals.	_____	_____	_____
6. I am flexible to changes that affect my progress toward my goals.	_____	_____	_____
7. I know the benefits of reaching my goals.	_____	_____	_____
8. I am persistent about working toward my goals.	_____	_____	_____
9. I review my progress toward my goals on a regular basis.	_____	_____	_____
10. I achieve a balance of effort between the goals that are important to me.	_____	_____	_____
11. I only pursue those activities that are related to reaching my goals.	_____	_____	_____

Assess your responses to this exercise by counting the number of times that you responded “Often” and multiply that number by 3. Multiply the number of times that you responded “Sometimes” by 2, and the number of times that you responded “Rarely/Never” by 1. Then add the resulting three numbers for a total score.

Eleven Strategies to Optimize Reaching Your Goals

Often	_____ (number of responses) × 3 = _____
Sometimes	_____ (number of responses) × 2 = _____
Rarely	_____ (number of responses) × 1 = _____
GRAND TOTAL = _____	

Analyzing Your Score

Score of:

33–39	You have a healthy understanding of what it takes to see your goals accomplished.
26–32	You are well on your way to developing the personal discipline for reaching your goals.
19–25	You will find the information in this chapter useful as you sharpen the skills for reaching your goals.

Strategies for Staying Power

The statements to which you responded relate to strategies that encourage your “staying power” when working toward a goal. Most of us benefit from strategies that strengthen our resolve. Each of these strategies is discussed in detail in this chapter. As you read, note your areas of strength as well as opportunities for improvement.

WORK WITH GOALS THAT ARE COMPATIBLE

When goals conflict with one another they compete for your time, energy, and personal resources, which can leave you feeling drained and stressed. For example, a manager was challenged by his boss to spend more time on the production floor interacting with his employees, and then was criticized for not spending enough time at his desk. To him, these two goals were in conflict with one another.

Another example is the manager who wanted to complete her doctorate. She enrolled at a university and was beginning her studies when she learned that she was pregnant. In analyzing the situation, she discovered that the goals of pursuing an education, maintaining a full-time job, and starting a family were not compatible at that time. Trying to meet the challenges of these goals would deplete her resources of energy, time, and enthusiasm.

Review your goals. Which ones are competing for your resources? How can you modify or change your goals so that they are more compatible?

BE WILLING TO ASK FOR HELP WITH YOUR GOALS

Many people are willing to help you if you ask for their assistance. Specify your needs and identify specific ways in which others can help. Remember, part of the way you can repay the help you receive is to be a resource for others.

Whose skills, knowledge, and/or gifts can help you reach one or more of your goals?

Which of your skills, knowledge, and/or gifts can you use to help someone else?

ACCEPT THE RESPONSIBILITY FOR DOING THE WORK THAT IS

NECESSARY TO REACH YOUR GOALS

Establishing goals is a start. Accepting the responsibility to accomplish them is another challenge. When the going gets tough, many people begin to blame others for their lack of progress. Instead of getting caught in a defensive, blaming trap, apply your time and energy to solving problems, making decisions, and working your plan so that your goals are realized.

How do you typically react when faced with a problem?

Does your reaction get in the way of your potential success?

Are you willing to change your behavior? If so, how?

MINIMIZE THE INTERRUPTIONS THAT BLOCK YOUR PROGRESS TOWARD YOUR GOALS

Many interruptions have the appearance of urgency and importance, but often they are time wasters and trivial matters. When an interruption arises, quickly evaluate it in terms of its importance to your goals. If it is not an enabler to your progress, then it may be a hindrance.

Do you control interruptions or do interruptions control you?

Do you handle interruptions swiftly and decisively?

What specific actions can you take to minimize the interruptions to your day?

BE FLEXIBLE TO CHANGES THAT AFFECT YOUR PROGRESS TOWARD A GOAL

Although a planned path optimizes progress toward your goals, the unexpected does sometimes arise and can either impede or facilitate progress. When an unforeseen change in your plan occurs, evaluate it for damage control. Brainstorm alternatives to eliminate or minimize the impact of the problem, but also look for opportunities!

An advertising agency that was growing quickly felt several pressures affecting its progress toward its five-year goal of becoming known nationally for creative thinking. The company’s president died unexpectedly, a multimillion-dollar account was lost, the economy forced several other clients to drop the services, and several key management people left the company. Instead of allowing these changes to debilitate the company, agency executives sought opportunities in the challenges. They streamlined the agency, recommitted themselves to a vision of what the agency could be, and sought outside assistance to strengthen skills.

What are the potential problems or changes that could get in the way of reaching one of your goals?

What actions will you take to optimize your opportunities and minimize potential problems?

Action to Optimize	Action to Minimize

IDENTIFY THE BENEFITS OF REACHING YOUR GOALS

Get tuned into WII-FM (What’s in It for Me?). Knowing and wanting the goal’s benefits is a key factor in motivating you to apply your time, energy, and resources. No salesperson is successful without an effort to sell the benefits of a product or a service to the client. So sell your goal’s benefits to yourself. Perhaps the benefits include exposure to upper management, a chance to learn something new, or the opportunity for a promotion. When you value the benefit that you’ll receive, that value increases your motivation to reach the goal.

What factors motivate you to work toward a particular goal?

What are the benefits of reaching one or more of your goals?

DEVELOP THE PERSISTENCE TO WORK TOWARD YOUR GOALS

Persistence may be the most important quality for reaching your goals. Many people are willing to quit when the going gets rough. What about you? Are you willing to make short-term sacrifices in order to accomplish something that is meaningful to you?

Consider your goals. On a scale of 1 to 10 (10 = high), how important are your goals to you?

If you believe that they are important, do you have the persistence to work toward your goals?

REVIEW YOUR PROGRESS TOWARD YOUR GOALS REGULARLY

Reviewing your goals not only identifies the progress you've made, but also provides an opportunity to ensure that you are on track and that you have adequate resources at your disposal. A review of your goals also fans the fire of motivation by highlighting your accomplishments. Consider posting a list of your goals so you can see them on a daily basis. Charting your progress regularly is also motivating.

Do you make a point of reviewing your goals on a regular basis?

Would charting your progress increase your motivation?

BALANCE YOUR EFFORTS AMONG THE GOALS THAT ARE IMPORTANT TO YOU

Often we find ourselves applying a disproportionate amount of time to certain goals. One successful realtor who sold 7 million dollars' worth of real estate in a year realized that while she said that her family was very important to her, in reality she did not share much of her time and energy with them. Instead, most of her resources went to her job. Those long hours might ensure job performance, but goals related to other areas of life (family, friends, community, or spiritual life) may suffer.

In [Chapter 1](#) you identified goals related to different areas of your life. Do you apply

adequate amounts of time, energy, and resources to each of those areas that are important to you? If not, what changes are you willing to make?

**REACH YOUR GOALS BY CONCENTRATING ON THOSE THINGS
THAT RELATE TO YOUR GOALS**

Whatever activities are planned in your day, consider their value to reaching your goals. Frequently, there are activities that you can eliminate or modify so that you can concentrate on making progress toward your significant goals.

Are you willing to give priority to those activities that contribute specifically to your goals? How can you do this?

Experiencing progress toward goals that are meaningful to you is gratifying and can motivate you toward even more accomplishments. Using these eleven strategies nearly guarantees progress toward reaching your goals. Prepare to reap the benefits of your effort!